

Overcalls

Because of the Defensive element, the most important requirement for an Overcall is that you have a good suit, one that you'd like partner to lead. Keep in mind:

- a 5-card or longer suit with honor strength

- 9-16 points to overcall at the 1-level

- 11-16 points to overcall at the 2-level

Takeout Doubles

There are three kinds of Takeout Double:

- opening hand strength, no more than 2 of opponent's suit, at least 3 in all other suits
- strong Overcall type, at least 17 points and a good suit. Double, then bid the suit.
- strong Notrump type, 19+ points, stopper in their suit. Double, then bid notrump.

Responding to a Takeout Double

- 0-8 points, bid your best suit as cheaply as possible

- 9-11 points, jump in your best suit

- 12 or more points, cue-bid the opponent's suit

Board: 1

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 1♠

Declarer: North

Lead: ♦ Q

Board: 2

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠

Declarer: East

Lead: ♥ K

Board: 3

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3♠

Declarer: South

Lead: ♥ A

Board: 4

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠

Declarer: West

Lead: ♦ 4

Board 1

West Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 8
♥ A 6 4 3
♦ 8 5 4 3
♣ A K J

♠ A K J 7 4

♥ 8 7

♦ A 7 6

♣ Q 5 4



♠ 5 3

♥ K Q J 10

♦ Q J 10 2

♣ 10 7 3

♠ Q 9 6 2

♥ 9 5 2

♦ K 9

♣ 9 8 6 2

NORTH has an opening hand, 15 points, and a 5-card ♠ suit. Unfortunately WEST beat her to the punch by opening 1♥.

But NORTH should get into the bidding anyway, by Overcalling 1♠. This shows a good ♠ suit and somewhere between 9 and 16 points.

SOUTH has 6 points. If NORTH had actually OPENED 1♠, SOUTH would be obligated to bid. But knowing that the Overcall will not be made with more than 16 points, SOUTH just passes.

West

1♥

North

1♠

*East**South*

All Pass

1♠ by North

Lead: ♦Q

Board 2

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q 9 6 2

♥ 10 5 2

♦ K Q 4

♣ K J 6

♠ 5 3

♥ Q 6 4 3

♦ 10 5 3 2

♣ A 10 9

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A K J 7 4

♥ 8 7

♦ A 7 6

♣ Q 5 4

♠ 10 8

♥ A K J 9

♦ J 9 8

♣ 8 7 3 2

*West**North**East**South*

1 ♥

1 ♠

Pass

2 ♠

Pass

4 ♠

All Pass

4 ♠ by East

Lead: ♥K

EAST has an opening hand, 15 points and five ♠s. But NORTH beat him to the punch, so he overcalls 1 ♠.

WEST has 11 points, and if EAST had opened she would make a Limit Raise to 3 ♠.

But when replying to an Overcall, the strength needs to be a little higher. In Deal 1 it was OK to pass a 1 ♠ Overcall with 6 points, here it is correct to just raise to 2 ♠ with 11 points.

EAST actually has a strong Overcall so he bids 4 ♠.

Board 3

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ 5 3
 ♥ A K J 3
 ♦ Q 10 3 2
 ♣ A 9 3

♠ Q 9 6 2

♥ 10 5 2

♦ A K

♣ K 8 6 2



♠ 10 8
 ♥ Q 9 6 4
 ♦ J 8 5 4
 ♣ Q 10 7

♠ A K J 7 4

♥ 8 7

♦ 9 7 6

♣ J 5 4

This time SOUTH has just 10 points, nowhere near an opening hand. Still, when EAST opens 1♥ SOUTH should Overcall 1♠. This shows a good ♠ suit and somewhere between 9 and 16 points.

NORTH has 13 points. If SOUTH had actually OPENED 1♠, NORTH would insist on game. But SOUTH didn't Open, she just Overcalled. So NORTH must be more cautious. He jumps to 3♠ and SOUTH shows her minimum type hand by passing.

*West**North**East**South*

1♥

1♠

Pass

3♠

All Pass

3♠ by South

Lead: ♥A

Board 4

North Deals

Both Vul

♠ A 10 5 3
♥ 10 7 5
♦ Q 8
♣ A 8 6 2

♠ 7 4 2

♥ Q 9 8 2

♦ 9 6 4 2

♣ J 10



♠ K 9 8 6

♥ 4

♦ A K 7 3

♣ K Q 7 5

♠ Q J

♥ A K J 6 3

♦ J 10 5

♣ 9 4 3

EAST has 15 points, a singleton in the opponent's suit and 4-card support for any suit partner might name. In other words, a perfect Takeout Double.

WEST needs to make a medium-strong bid to apprise EAST of her 10 points. She jumps to 2♠.

EAST's hand is now worth 17 points because of the singleton. Since he is quite happy with ♠s he bids 4♠.

*West**North**East**South*

2♠

1♥

Dbl

Pass

Pass

4♠

All Pass

4♠ by West

Lead: ♦4